

The Spice Route

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A Kolkata-based dancer fuses dance with life skills to make sure that differently abled children come to terms with the challenges of daily living



PRITI PATEL (IN RED)
AND ANJI STAFF
DISPLAY THEIR SPICES

| By Elora Sen |

Priti Patel wears many hats. This exponent of Manipuri dance has taken her art beyond the boundaries of the performing stage and touched lives in a different way. Her organisation, Anjika, has given a new meaning to the lives of differently abled children through dance therapy. And then she set up Anji, an organisation that produces spices ground by hand, so that these children can earn a living and be productive members of society.

It is the members of Anjika—Marina Samuel, 29, Sharmistha Seal, 31, Jhuma Dey, 32, and Surya Sekhar Basu, 31—all differently abled, who run Anji. Having spent more than 15 years with Priti, one day they asked her, “Didi, how can we earn for ourselves?” “It was then that I thought there must be something they can do which will be within their abilities. I wanted to create a system where they could live on their own terms—gain self-respect and be responsible,” says the dancer. Thus Anji was born, with its spices workshop in a south Kolkata flat. Raw spices are sourced from the wholesale market in Kidderpore and the team—Marina, Sharmistha, Jhuma and Surya—grinds, weighs and

packs them. Surya’s mother, Sharmila Basu, supervises the team while chef, Palash Sarkar of Soho—a popular fine-dining spot—and Anji guarantee quality.

Marina, good with numbers, keeps the accounts and takes care of marketing. “I don’t feel I am handicapped. I can now earn for myself and I feel good about that.” Her partners echo her words as they know that they have to pay back their loan to Anjika. “They understand that this is a business that they have to run. And they know they have to compete with the best in the market. We will also introduce handicrafts as many children at Anjika are good with their hands,” says Priti.

Anji sells its products to top Kolkata restaurants as well as to private buyers. In fact, a consignment has been sent to Japan to explore new markets. “We are just a few months old and I am confident that by next year we will be able to introduce more products and involve more differently abled people. My sole aim is to give them a life of respect where they stop thinking that someone else has to take care of them,” says Priti with a smile. From dance therapy to creating livelihood opportunities, Anjika sure has come a long way. ■